

to the inevitable. They get the degree that is supposedly “better” than the one they really wanted. If they’re fortunate enough to get a job, they cling to it. People with Banality 6 do what they have to for as long as they must, and retreat from the world around them as soon as is possible. They have hopes and dreams of making it big doing the thing they love, but cruel reality is an insurmountable obstacle more often than not. When left to their own devices, they produce some Glamour, but are hardly the fonts of it as are those of lower Banality, whom they envy greatly.

Banality 7

The battle may not be over, but the war seems lost. At this level of Banality, an individual feels beaten. He knows he should write that novel that’s been lingering in the back of his head, but zoning out on the couch watching competitive cooking TV shows is just *easier*. The set of high-end markers sits in a corner gathering dust — her guild in Skinner Box Online gives her shit if she doesn’t make at least two raids a week. Their dreams are still within their sight, but their reach exceeds their grasp. Someone suffering with this much Banality needs a real shock to get him out of his rut, so getting Glamour from him is a challenge.

Banality 8

The Banality begins not only to dampen, but to control souls at this level. It’s not a maniacal puppeteer, cackling as it makes people dance at its whim, but is rather a further refinement of what it already does at lower levels. It takes the envy of a freer soul and twists it, turning it to antipathy. Mortals begin to pose a threat to Kithain once they reach this level of Banality, forcing changelings to ever be on their guard, lest they be overwhelmed by even a careless word. The mortal does not mean to be a threat, but this makes no difference. A nasty comment about street art seems innocuous to many, but it plants the seeds of Banality and inflames the sliver of it that all changelings carry within them.

Banality 9–10

Not everyone with a Banality rating this high is an Autumn Person, but one could forgive changelings for not seeing the difference. This level of Banality is a choking cloud of hopelessness, a vortex of negativity that seems inescapable. The person at the heart of that cloud, who exudes it with practically every word and action, disdains creativity to such an extent that it seems *wrong* to them. Here, a psychologist overprescribes medication for an attention disorder. Here, funding for arts programs is cut even when options to save them exist. Here, the bright wash of color in the world, attenuated slowly as Banality progresses, is rendered a malignant and dying collection of shades of gray.

Where Angels Fear to Tread

The chill of Banality contaminates not only people or objects, but even entire locations or buildings. Such places require long-term exposure to Banal thought, making them comparatively rarer than individuals with high Banality, but they do exist and they are a great threat to changelings. Banal

structures represent the institutional memory of the organizations that dwell within or use them regularly. Organizations dedicated to promulgating one point of view above all others are a common cause of such structures. Not every church is a Banal structure, but a megachurch owned by a fire-and-brimstone preacher who insists that everyone except his parishioners is on a one-way road to Hell certainly will be. A business that thrives on creativity and has a loose management structure is less likely to be saturated with Banality, but the stereotypical office-drone cubicle farm filled with workers endlessly performing rote tasks that have no relation to their own lives might as well be the Chernobyl of Banality. Rejection of alternative ideas, of creativity, and of imagination are all hallmarks of the sorts of organizations needed to create a Banal structure.

It takes pervasive, constant, long-term Banal thought to create a truly Banal structure, where Banality is dangerous even when mortals are absent. Some structures, such as the ones mentioned above, fit the bill nicely. Most locations, however, have a fluctuating Banality rating, largely dependent on the mood of the mortals who are making use of it at the time, which reflects the current ambient Banality. A school at recess has a lower Banality rating, as the imaginations of children at play wear away at Banality’s grasp. Come back half an hour later, and Banality is back in full swing, as those imaginations are crushed beneath the weight of demands to memorize lists of state-mandated facts that will be tested to determine their performance (and thus the budget allocation for that school for the next year) — woe to the changeling caught at the school on the day that test is given, as the building will no doubt suffer a major spike in Banality.

System: When deciding the Banality rating of the structure, consider what the Banality rating of the average member of the organization that made it that way would be. Factor in how many of them there are, how long they’ve been there, and how active they are, and you should have a pretty good idea of where on the chart they belong. **Any rolls for cantrip use within a Banal structure suffer +1 to their difficulty.** Additionally, for every scene a changeling spends in a Banal structure in excess of her Glamour rating, she gains a point of temporary Banality.

Mortals who regularly spend time in a Banal structure with a higher Banality rating than their own slowly gain Banality until they reach an equilibrium with the structure. This gain occurs at the rate of one dot of Banality per month. This assumes they spend a significant portion of their waking hours within the structure, such as for a nine-to-five job. If they spend less time in the structure, they may gain Banality at a slower rate or not at all, at Storyteller discretion. Similarly, if they are locked in or otherwise forced to spend 24 hours a day in such a structure, their Banality rating rises much quicker than usual.

Gaining Banality

Exposure to the modern world results in the slow buildup of Banality in every changeling’s soul. This is an unavoidable consequence of existence in their present form, but is preferable by far to the permanent destruction of the faerie self.